

Prologue - "White and Black"

Translated by: Sir Eggface the Forth

???: [■■■■■·■■■■■■■]

Passing through skin, flesh, and bone, it was a sensation that seemed to have licked her very soul.

A sense of loss that gave rise to dread, writhing in agony, and the welling up of tears; by the transpiration of that, this body was released from the birdcage that had confined it, and tossed out into the world.

——That, had been a Contract.

A one-sided Contract, selfish to no end, one that did not take her opinion into any account whatsoever.

As for why such a thing had been done to her, she wanted to voice a complaint. Despite wanting to voice it, she could not do so. ——After all, both her feelings and reason for doing so, had completely disappeared.

???: [Kuhahaha, so rubbish it's a damn masterpiece! Just what sorta guy was it and who in the world were they for their discretion to lead to such a damn troublesome situation? It's so revolting that it's hilarious!]

Bending his body in an exaggerated manner, that man cackled loud and foolishly.

Similar circumstances, and close positions. Inferring that such was the case from the situation they had been placed in, her sense of wariness still maintained a fixed distance between herself and the other party. Merely, all the while, the man continued to cackle manically.

That laugh of his seemed to be cursing, ridiculing, and envying every last thing in this world, and for some reason, she felt like it was horribly wrenching her heart.

It hurt. Yet, it was not cold. Hence, she would not relinquish it. Such an urgency, was upon her.

Man: [Oi oi oi, are you normal, are you sane? Even if you're saying you took someone's hand on a night where you were so frightful and lonely that you couldn't sleep, you've gotta be a bit more careful in who pick for that. Or~ per~haps~, did you happen to like this faaaace?]

Deliberately putting on an unscrupulous act, the man contorted his face into a hideous grimace, to which she returned his gaze directly.

Perhaps due to her response having been unthinkable for him, it was clear that the man was bewildered. Though not to say that it had been her win for having bewildered him, at this time, she would assert it so.

If she asserted it, and defeated him with those words, she would no longer be alone. ——She felt like that was more important than anything else.

Man: [As expected, just as I thought, neither are you sane nor are you normal. Ahh, that's fine, quite fine! I was also getting fed up with the air and the atmosphere here! I'll go along with you for a while until I get tired.]

Taking the hand extended out to her with those words, they ran away together.

They ran away. Yes, they escaped. They had no choice but to run away. And for running away, it was now or never.

She was not alone. However, the person whom she truly wished to be with, she could not be with right now.

The words of her current self, would not be able to save that person. Her words could not keep him in place. The efforts she had built up to be able to do so, had been lost in exchange for freedom from the birdcage.

Man: [Don't cry, don't weep, laugh and sing! No matter how much you curse out, the sky is still blue and the flowers are still fragrant. Back there, you weren't even given the time to think about that. You are free. It's a freedom that you won, snatched, and wrested free. So with that depressed face... what do you wanna do? Indeed, what do you want to do?]

When she realized, she found that she was frozen in place, having progressed not even a single step either forward or backward.

And peering into her face, having lost its expression, the man put on the most villainous face he could muster, and reaching out both his arms, he began to mercilessly constrict her neck.

Man: [Kuhahahaha, a blue pallid completely pale face! If you've got nothing, then are you fine with ending it here? Are you satisfied with things ending here, with everything up to here? Don't worry, don't worry. After all, all humans are alone when they die!]

Clasped by the man's hands as he laughed and wrung her neck, she writhed, wrested, and fervently struggled.

Until just a moment ago, she had forgotten how to even breathe. And yet, it was strange. For what reason was she resisting against this agony, and still seeking the next? For what reason, did she find the notion of ending things unpleasant?

How long would it take for her to realize that even such troubling thoughts were mere luxuries when life was on the line?

Man: [What, something the matter, you're still going to struggle? People who don't know when to give up, I'm getting fed up with them!]

While saying that, the man let go of her neck, and her body reclaimed both its freedom, and its life.

The flow of her tears and snot served as proof that she had clung to her life.

She quickly accepted that the tenacity to yet writhe and struggle existed within herself.

And, if she had found the value in her own life, she began to covet what lay ahead.

Man: [Is that how you feel, feeling determined to do it? How bold and selfish, and that's just fine! Rather than sobbing in depression while being drunk on tragedy, there's far more avail in causing a stir!]

It was surprisingly easy to deal with the man's elusive words and conduct once she got used to him and learned how to interact with him.

All along, she had been good at crossing the boundary that separated her from others. —Whether she desired it or not, it was to the extent that it impacted the lives of even those she held dear.

And, the fact that she could not bring herself to think of it as one-sided, made it a gift that she did not deserve.

Man: [Weeeeell then, what will you do, what shall you do? Given your will to live has expressly surged up here, by all means please lead the way! If it seems amusing I'll follow along! If it seems a bore, then that will be it for me!]

Unfortunately, she did not intend on currying favor with the man. But, she somewhat understood.

That actively not trying to curry favor with him, was the best way to put the man in a good mood.

Besides, though she still did not know what she ought to do, she had at least already decided on what she desired.

Man: [Kuhahahaha! What's with those eyes, a good performance? They seem like the eyes of a woman who's gonna destroy the world, you know!]

Loudly cackling, the man spoke some rather unexpected things.

But, by some chance, he might have been right. The world was not something she actively wished to destroy, but perhaps, in some unlikely event, if that were to be necessary...

■■■■: [Let us do what is necessary. ——So that I may reclaim my own life.]

——Certainly, in order to obtain what she desired, she believed she at least needed to be ready to destroy the world, or else she would not even be able to rise to the stage that so concerned it.